

religion GURUVAYUR TEMPLE

■ By M. G. Radhakrishnan

After the sari, a churidar with kurta is the attire most preferred by women in India, but those who run Kerala's famed Guruvayur temple and even Lord Krishna, the presiding deity do not agree. If they are to be believed, a recent *ashtamangala prasna*, an elaborate week-long astrological exercise, held in the temple, has "revealed" over 150-odd "likes" and "dislikes" of Lord Krishna. The *prasna* was held after 17 years at the initiative of the state-appointed Guruvayur Devaswom Board (GDB), which administers the shrine to Sree Krishna, south India's third-richest temple after Tirupati and Sabarimala. It came close on the heels of GDB, along with a few Hindu organisations, deciding in



Dressing Up for the Lord

The LDF Government-appointed board that runs the Guruvayur temple wants to introduce radical reforms, but a section of the faithful accuse the Left of interfering in Hindu religious matters

February to lift the ban on women entering the temple in churidars and also considering revoking the bar on the entry of non-Hindus.

"Irrespective of whether they suit changing times or not, the exercise has revealed that the Lord doesn't approve of changes in the temple traditions," says Padmanabha Sarma, who headed the team that conducted the *prasna*.

The existing practice in most Kerala temples is to allow bare-chested men inside with a *mundu* (dhoti) while women could wear either a sari or *mundu*. But the fairer sex is not to blame for the dress code. The decision to ban churidars was taken after a piece of cloth was cut the wrong way at a ritual held in relation to the *prasna*.

Now the whole exercise has put many who had supported the withdrawal of the ban on the defensive. "It's right we agreed to revoke both the bans. But if GDB was planning an *ashtamangala prasna*, we could have waited for its directives. By custom, GDB has to follow all the directives of the *prasna*," says Rajasekharan, vice-president of the state unit of VHP. He adds that a

consensus could still be achieved through a conference of all concerned.

Chennas Raman Namboodiripad, the head priest of Guruvayur temple has done a volte face in the face of stiff opposition. After initially agreeing to the withdrawal of the ban on churidars, he now says the decisions were taken in haste and under "some pressure". "This temple is different from others because of its traditional customs and rituals. Any decision to change them should have been taken only after more elaborate discussions," says Chennas Dinesan Namboodiripad, a member of the priest's family. "Today it is the churidar. Tomorrow it could be pants. Where can one draw a line if rituals can be changed so easily?"

Ironically, the *prasna* has found fault with various deeds of the head priest himself, and has even directed him to atone for them by reciting a

particular Sanskrit shloka one lakh times. Other atonement measures to be conducted by GDB include a host of prayers in temples and a vaastu-based reconstruction of some structures.

Reforms and controversy are not new to the temple. In the recent past, singer K. J. Yesudas, a Christian and a devotee of Krishna, was denied entry despite being recommended by G. Sudhakaran, state temple affairs minister in the LDF Government. In another incident, Raman Namboodiripad ordered the cleansing of the entire shrine after Ravikrishnan, son of Vayalar Ravi, Union minister for overseas Indian affairs, entered the temple. The priests labelled Ravikrishnan a non-Hindu since his mother Mercy Ravi was Christian. Ravi then threatened to sue the temple authorities.

Keeping in mind the political implications of the cleansing ritual, a



"Thanks to the government's intervention, some heinous practices were put to an end."

G. SUDHAKARAN, TEMPLE AFFAIRS MINISTER